The Latke Who Couldn't Stop Screaming: A Christmas Story

By Lemony Snicket (aka Daniel Handler)

NARRATOR: This story begins in a tiny village more or less covered in snow. The snow had fallen during the long night during which children had pressed their faces to the windows looking for the glimpse of a man who they suspected of bringing them wonderful gifts. *(screaming)* But instead, they heard a terrible noise *(screaming)* from a certain cottage in the neighboring "***arrondissement***," a word which means "place where something is being born." This cottage, already regarded with some suspicion, was the only place not decorated with flashing colored lights at this time of year. [And] the thing being born was a "***latke***," a word which means "potato pancake." *(repeated screaming)*

INTRODUCTION

The Christmas season – a time of music, endless rounds of Christmas specials on every streaming service and malls decked to the rafters with tinsel, lights and every decoration imaginable. But for the Jewish population the holiday season is – well – different. What does it feel like to live in a society that is constantly pummeling you with religious messages that are not your own?

In Lemony Snicket's tale, we find a latke who is really looking for two things, a sense of belonging, and for others to listen and acknowledge the importance of his differences. After all, isn't that what we all are searching for?

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NARRATOR: Latkes are a traditional part of the celebration of Chanukah – a holiday commemorating a miraculous Jewish military victory. *(interrupted by screaming)*

Nearly everything in this world is born screaming, and the latke was no exception. Even though the latke wasn't conceived and born the way you and I were, instead he was fashioned from grated potatoes, chopped onion, beaten eggs and a dash or two of salt. Once these ingredients were properly mixed, the latke was slapped into a pan full of olive oil, heated to a very high temperature, and this is when he began to scream.

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LATKE: ARGHHHHHHHHH! ARGHHHHHHHHHH!

NARRATOR: The latke was suffering so much that he leapt out of the hot pan, out of the window and began to run screaming down the boulevard.

LATKE: ARGHHHHHHHHH!

NARRATOR: This may seem like unusual behavior for a potato pancake, but this is a Christmas story in which things tend to happen that would never occur in real life. The latke ran past a row of flashing colored lights, which hung from the rain gutters of a less suspicious cottage.

LIGHTS: What's all the ruckus? We're the ones who are supposed to be dominating the neighborhood with our cheerful glow.

LATKE: I was just thrown into a pan of boiling oil! Can you believe it?

LIGHTS: Yes, but we can't imagine why.

LATKE: Because I'm a latke. The olive oil reminds us of the oil used to re-dedicate the temple following the defeat of Antiochus at the hands of the Maccabees. The oil was only supposed to last for one night, but there was a miracle and it lasted for eight. Plus frying makes my skin crispy and brown.

LIGHTS: So you are basically hashbrowns. Maybe you can be served alongside a Christmas ham.

LATKE: I'm not hashbrowns! I'm something completely different. *(runs off screaming)* ARGHHHHHHH! ARGHHHHH!

NARRATOR: The latke rounded the corner and found himself face to face with a candy cane which wrinkled its red and white nose at the latke in distaste.

CANDY CANE: I'm trying to sprinkle the night air with my peppermint scent. Your mouth-watering smell, not to mention all that yelping, is spoiling the effect.

LATKE: My mouth-watering smell is part of the cozy feeling of Chanukah. It reminds us that things are better now than they were in 175 BCE when my people were not allowed to practice their religion. In order to study the Torah, they had to hide out in caves. And when they heard Greek soldiers approach, they pretended they were gambling with a small spinning top called a "***dreidel***."

CANDY CANE: Sort of like Joseph and Mary hiding out in the manager. Someone should write a

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Christmas carol about you.

LATKE: I'm not part of Christmas! It's a totally different thing! *(runs off screaming)* ARGGGGHHHH! ARGHHHHHH!

NARRATOR: The screams of the latke grew quieter and quieter as the pancake ran out of the village into the surrounding forest. Its utter fury was unabated – a phrase which means "the latke was still very annoyed at the objects to whom it had spoken." But it was quite tired, so it decided to rest for a few minutes beneath the branches of a little pine tree. The pine tree was napping but woke up at the sound of an object plopping down at its feet.

PINE TREE: Are you a present? Presents are pretty much the only things allowed to sit beneath me this time of year.

LATKE: *(heavy sigh, then in a hoarse voice from screaming so much)* Presents aren't really a big part of Chanukah. There's nothing wrong with giving gifts to loved ones, of course. But it's more important to light the candles for eight consecutive nights to commemorate the miracle in the temple and the miracle of victory when you are thoroughly outnumbered so you shouldn't give up hope.

PINE TREE: Plus . . . Santa Claus!

NARRATOR: The latke was too exhausted to scream.

LATKE: Santa Clause has nothing to do with it. Christmas and Chanukah are complete different things.

PINE TREE: But different things can often blend together. Let me tell you a funny story about pagan rituals.

NARRATOR: But before the pine tree could begin its story, a family came trooping through the snow, searching the forest carefully.

FATHER: *(holding an axe on his shoulder)* We shouldn't have waited until the last minute to get ready for the holiday. We'll never find a good one.

MOTHER: You shouldn't give up hope. *(pointing to the pine tree)* Look!

DAUGHTER: It's perfect!

SON: Beautiful.

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MOTHER: Such a marvelous shape.

FATHER: And its skin looks so crispy! *(reaching down and scooping up the latke)* We'll need to reheat it, of course. But this will be perfect for Chanukah dinner with a topping applesauce, sour cream or even jam.

MOTHER: I'll refry it in oil to remind us of the rededication of the temple.

DAUGHTER: And the triumph of the Maccabees over Antiochus!

SON: After hiding in caves all that time . . .

FATHER: *(smiling at the latke in his hand)* What was I thinking, bringing this axe?

NARRATOR: The family strolled back to the village, walking past all the cottages with flashing colored lights and smiling politely at the candy canes. The family carried the latke into their home which was warm and cozy and sat down at the table, which was lit with the flickering candles of a menorah or "***chanukkiyah***" which is a branched candelabra designed specifically for the holiday.

It is very frustrating not to be understood in this world. If you say one thing and keep being told that you mean something else, it can make you want to scream. But somewhere in the world, there is a place for all of us whether you are an electric form of decoration . . .

LIGHTS: What's all the ruckus? We're the ones who are supposed to be dominating the neighborhood with our cheerful glow.

NARRATOR: A peppermint scented sweet. . .

CANDY CANE: I'm trying to sprinkle the night air with my peppermint scent.

NARRATOR: A source of timber . . .

PINE TREE: Are you a present? Presents are the only things allowed to sit beneath me this time of year. Plus . . . Santa Claus! *(screaming)*

NARRATOR: Or . . . a potato pancake.

LATKE: *(screaming)*

NARRATOR: On a cold snowy night, everyone and everything should be welcome somewhere . . . and the latke was welcomed into a home full of people who understood what a latke is and how it fits into its particular holiday.

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And then they ate it . . . .

LATKE: ARGHHHH . . UMMMMM! *(scream muffled by the munching of Father)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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